

A War by Any Other Name Would Smell As Sweet:

Grey Zone Competition, the Western Response and Policy Recommendations

*A comparative and policy analysis of cyber, maritime, and informational coercion by Russia,
China, Iran, United Kingdom, and the United States*

Ian Mungwadzi

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Abstract

This paper examines the rising significance of grey zone competition in 21st century international security. It argues that hostile state actors — principally Russia, the People's Republic of China, and the Islamic Republic of Iran — have systematically exploited the legal, doctrinal and political space below the threshold of armed conflict to pursue strategic objectives that conventional military forces could not achieve at acceptable cost. Through a comparative survey of three doctrinally distinct approaches and an examination of cyber, maritime, and informational tools, the paper contends that liberal democracies such as the United States remain structurally disadvantaged in this domain. The closing sections outline policy directions for the United Kingdom and its allies, with particular attention to attribution capacity, deterrence-by-denial, and the integration of civil and military instruments of power.

1. Introduction

The post-1945 international order rested on a clear, if imperfect, distinction between war and peace. The United Nations Charter prohibited the threat or use of force in international relations, while a network of treaties - most notably the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons - sought to constrain the most catastrophic forms of escalation. For the better part of six or seven decades, this architecture functioned well as a framework for great-power competition.

That framework is now under sustained pressure. Since the early 2010s, a growing body of strategic literature has identified a recurring pattern: hostile actors employing tools of coercion that fall deliberately below the threshold at which a kinetic military response could plausibly be justified. The result is a form of competition that is neither war nor peace, but something else - what analysts have variously termed *hybrid*, or, most commonly, *grey zone* warfare.¹

This paper makes three claims.

- First, that grey zone competition is not a transient phenomenon but a durable feature of the contemporary international system, reflecting both the disincentives surrounding direct conflict between nuclear-armed states and the increasing range of non-kinetic tools available to ambitious actors.
- Second, that Russia, China and Iran have each developed distinct but overlapping doctrines for grey zone operations, and that comparative analysis reveals important differences in objective, method and risk tolerance.
- Third, that the response of the United Kingdom and its allies has so far been reactive, fragmented and insufficient — and that meaningful improvement requires structural reform rather than incremental adjustment.

The paper proceeds in five further sections. Section 2 defines the grey zone and surveys its conceptual lineage. Section 3 outlines the principal tools used in grey zone operations, with particular attention to cyber capabilities and a brief discussion of emerging autonomous and robotic systems. Section 4 presents three comparative case studies. Section 5 analyses why open societies struggle to respond to sub-threshold coercion. Section 6 offers a set of policy recommendations.

¹Mazarr MJ. *Mastering the Gray Zone: Understanding a Changing Era of Conflict*. Carlisle (PA): US Army War College Press; 2015. p. 1–15.

2. Defining the Grey Zone

There is no universally accepted definition of grey zone warfare, and the term itself is contested. The RAND Corporation analyst Michael Mazarr, in one of the earliest sustained treatments of the concept, characterises grey zone activity as competition that is *deliberate, gradualist and ambiguous* — pursued by actors who wish to alter the status quo without triggering a decisive military or political response.² Frank Hoffman, who originally popularised the related concept of *hybrid warfare*, has argued that the grey zone is best understood as a posture rather than a doctrine: a calibrated mode of pressure that exploits the legal, normative and procedural seams of the international order.³

Public statements by senior British officials reflect a similar understanding. The former Secretary of State for Defence, Ben Wallace, observed that adversaries pursuing successful grey zone strategies might never need to commit conventional forces at all: pressure could be applied through proxies, through cyber operations, or through the deliberate degradation of an adversary's economy, such that the conditions for a conventional advance — should one ever be needed — had already been established.⁴

Three features of the concept warrant emphasis. First, grey zone activity is fundamentally *competitive rather than belligerent*: the actor does not seek to defeat the adversary in open battle, but to accumulate marginal gains that, in aggregate, alter the strategic balance in favour of the aggressor. Second, grey zone activity exploits *ambiguity of attribution*: the use of proxies, deniable assets, and dual-use technologies makes it difficult for the targeted state to assemble a public, defensible case for retaliation. Third, grey zone activity exploits *ambiguity of category*: where a given act sits on the spectrum between vandalism, espionage, sabotage and armed attack is rarely self-evident, and the resulting interpretive uncertainty paralyses response.

It is this third feature that makes the grey zone strategically distinctive. A maritime militia vessel ramming a fishing boat, a cargo ship dragging its anchor across an undersea cable, or a state-sponsored intrusion into a power utility's industrial control systems each occupies a

³Hoffman FG. On not-so-new warfare: political warfare vs hybrid threats. War on the Rocks. 2014 Jul 28. Available from: <https://warontherocks.com/2014/07/on-not-so-new-warfare-political-warfare-vs-hybrid-threats/>

⁴Wallace B, Secretary of State for Defence. Speech at the Royal United Services Institute. London: RUSI; 2021 Jul 13.

category that conventional doctrine was not designed to address. The grey zone is, in effect, the negative space of established international law.

3. The Grey Zone Toolkit

Grey zone operations draw on a wide and expanding inventory of instruments. The categories overlap, and a sophisticated campaign will typically combine several simultaneously. The following survey is necessarily selective; it foregrounds those tools most relevant to the case studies in Section 4.

3.1 Cyber operations

Cyber capabilities are the defining technology of the grey zone. They satisfy almost every criterion that a sub-threshold operation requires: they can be conducted at range, they offer high deniability, they impose costs disproportionate to their development expense, and they exploit infrastructures over which the targeted state has only partial control. The spectrum of cyber operations runs from low-intensity reconnaissance and credential harvesting, through disruptive attacks on commercial and government systems, to destructive operations against industrial control systems — the last of these representing what is sometimes termed the upper edge of the grey zone, where the line between cyber operation and armed attack becomes genuinely contested.

3.2 Information and influence operations

Information operations are the oldest of the grey zone tools, predating the digital era by centuries. What has changed is scale: the combination of social media platforms, programmatic advertising and algorithmic content distribution has lowered the marginal cost of influence to nearly zero. Contemporary information operations include the manipulation of domestic political discourse in target states, the manufacture of synthetic personas and content, the amplification of authentic but divisive material, and the strategic disclosure or fabrication of compromising information. Generative AI tools becoming more and more commonplace means now any technologically abled person has the ability to disseminate their own fake news campaigns. Scholars have already shown how false or misleading news can distort political debate, polarise societies, and weaken democratic institutions (<https://cepr.org/voxeu/columns/ai-misinformation-and-value-trusted-news>, Campante et al. 2025).

3.3 Maritime and physical-domain coercion

A growing share of grey zone activity is occurring in the physical domain — particularly at sea. Maritime militias, paramilitary coast guards, and ostensibly civilian shipping have been used to assert territorial claims, harass adversary vessels, and damage critical undersea infrastructure. Because such activity exploits the freedoms guaranteed by the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, and because attribution is genuinely difficult in the maritime environment, the cost of conducting such operations is low and the risk of escalation correspondingly small.

3.4 Economic and lawfare instruments

Economic coercion — the discriminatory use of trade, investment, and sanctions instruments to punish or reward foreign policy behaviour — sits at the more conventional end of the grey zone toolkit. So too does what is sometimes called *lawfare*: the strategic use of domestic and international legal processes to advance state objectives, whether through aggressive interpretation of international law (as in the South China Sea), or through the prosecution of dual nationals as bargaining chips.

3.5 Autonomous systems and emerging technologies

Autonomous and remotely operated systems represent the newest, and arguably the most uncertain, addition to the grey zone toolkit. Uncrewed aerial, surface and subsurface vehicles offer many of the same advantages that cyber operations do — distance, deniability and disposability — while extending those advantages into the kinetic domain. The use of cheap commercial drones for surveillance, harassment and small-scale strikes has been demonstrated in Ukraine, the Red Sea, and the Russo-Ukrainian Black Sea theatre, and there is now active concern that autonomous systems will be employed in support of grey zone operations against critical infrastructure outside of declared conflict zones. The legal and doctrinal frameworks for such operations remain underdeveloped.

4. Comparative Case Studies

The three case studies that follow have been selected to illustrate the doctrinal diversity of contemporary grey zone activity. Russia represents the most overt and aggressive practitioner; China the most patient and economically integrated; Iran the most reliant on proxy networks and asymmetric deterrence. Together they illustrate the breadth of the strategic challenge.

4.1 Russia: hybrid warfare and the weaponisation of disorder

Russian grey zone doctrine is most often associated, in Western analysis, with a 2013 article by General Valery Gerasimov, then Chief of the General Staff of the Russian Armed Forces. In it, Gerasimov argued that the line between war and peace had become blurred, and that non-military methods — political, economic, informational and humanitarian — had increased in importance to the point that they could exceed conventional weapons in their effectiveness.⁵ Western analysts subsequently coined the phrase *Gerasimov Doctrine* to describe this synthesis, although the term has been criticised as a misreading: as Mark Galeotti, who originated the label, has himself acknowledged, Gerasimov was describing what he believed the West was doing to Russia, not articulating an offensive blueprint of his own.⁶ Whatever the correct exegesis of the original text, the operational pattern that has emerged in Russian practice since 2014 is consistent with the doctrine as Western analysts have understood it.

Two illustrative episodes deserve attention. The first is the deployment of NotPetya in June 2017. NotPetya was a destructive wiper malware, disguised as ransomware, distributed via a compromised update mechanism in the M.E.Doc Ukrainian tax-preparation software. Although the apparent target was Ukraine — and the malware did indeed cause severe disruption to Ukrainian financial, energy and government systems — NotPetya propagated indiscriminately, ultimately causing damages estimated at over ten billion United States dollars worldwide and affecting major non-Ukrainian firms including Maersk, Merck and FedEx's TNT Express subsidiary.⁷ In February 2018, the United Kingdom government formally attributed the attack to the Russian military, with the United States and other Five Eyes partners following suit; in 2020, the United States Department of Justice indicted six officers of the GRU's Unit 74455, also known as Sandworm, in connection with the operation.^{8,9}

⁵Gerasimov V. The value of science is in the foresight: new challenges demand rethinking the forms and methods of carrying out combat operations. *Military Review*. 2016 Jan–Feb;96(1):23–29. (English translation; originally published in Voenno-Promyshlennyy Kuryer, 2013 Feb 27.)

⁶Galeotti M. The mythical 'Gerasimov Doctrine' and the language of threat. *Critical Studies on Security*. 2019;7(2):157–161.

⁷Greenberg A. *Sandworm: A New Era of Cyberwarfare and the Hunt for the Kremlin's Most Dangerous Hackers*. New York: Doubleday; 2019. p. 188–204.

⁸United Kingdom Foreign and Commonwealth Office. Foreign Office Minister condemns Russia for NotPetya attacks [press release]. London: FCO; 2018 Feb 15.

⁹United States Department of Justice. Six Russian GRU officers charged in connection with worldwide deployment of destructive malware and other disruptive actions in cyberspace [press release]. Washington (DC): DoJ; 2020 Oct 19.

The second is the ongoing campaign of suspected sabotage against undersea infrastructure in the Baltic Sea. Between October 2023 and early 2025, a series of incidents — the rupture of the Balticconnector gas pipeline, the cutting of the BCS East-West Interlink and C-Lion1 fibre-optic cables in November 2024, and the damage to the Estlink 2 power cable on Christmas Day 2024 — were attributed by European officials to deliberate action by vessels associated with Russia's so-called shadow fleet, in some cases with possible Chinese complicity.¹⁰ Although attribution in each individual case has been difficult to establish to a prosecutorial standard, the cumulative pattern has been sufficiently clear that NATO launched Operation Baltic Sentry in January 2025, dedicating maritime patrol assets, surveillance aircraft and naval drones to the protection of subsea infrastructure.¹¹

Two features of the Russian approach are worth highlighting. First, Russia's tolerance for collateral damage — exemplified by the indiscriminate spread of NotPetya — distinguishes its operations from those of more cautious adversaries. Second, the Russian model relies heavily on the deliberate cultivation of plausible deniability, even where the underlying facts are not in serious dispute. The shadow fleet, the use of nominally civilian vessels, the routing of cyber operations through compromised commercial infrastructure, and the persistent denial of involvement in the face of mounting forensic evidence all serve a single strategic function: to shift the burden of proof onto the targeted state, and to delay or deter retaliation while the underlying campaign continues.

4.2 China: the Three Warfares and the long horizon

The doctrinal foundations of Chinese grey zone activity differ markedly from those of Russia. Two texts are commonly cited as foundational. The first is *Unrestricted Warfare*, a 1999 work by two People's Liberation Army colonels, Qiao Liang and Wang Xiangsui, which argued that future conflicts would be waged across an expanded set of domains — financial, legal, ecological, informational — in which the asymmetric application of non-military instruments could compensate for inferiority in conventional military power.¹² The second is the doctrine of the *Three Warfares* (san zhong zhanfa) formally adopted by the Central Military Commission in 2003, which integrates psychological warfare, public opinion warfare, and legal

¹⁰Wilson Center. Risky game: hybrid attack on Baltic undersea cables. Washington (DC): Woodrow Wilson International Center for Scholars; 2024 Nov 22.

¹¹North Atlantic Treaty Organization. NATO launches 'Baltic Sentry' to enhance critical undersea infrastructure security [press release]. Brussels: NATO; 2025 Jan 14.

¹²Liang Q, Xiangsui W. *Unrestricted Warfare*. Beijing: PLA Literature and Arts Publishing House; 1999.

warfare under a unified strategic concept aimed at shaping the cognitive and normative environment in which Chinese interests are pursued.¹³

In operational terms, Chinese grey zone activity is most visible in the South China Sea. Since the early 2010s, the People's Republic of China has pursued a sustained campaign of land reclamation and militarisation across the disputed Spratly and Paracel island chains, building artificial features into fortified installations equipped with airstrips, sensor arrays and air defence systems. This activity has continued despite a 2016 award by the Permanent Court of Arbitration finding, in proceedings brought by the Philippines under Annex VII of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, that China's expansive maritime claims have no basis in international law.¹⁴ The award has had no observable effect on Chinese behaviour. Alongside the construction effort, China has employed its coast guard and a substantial maritime militia — fishing vessels operating, in effect, as paramilitary auxiliaries — to harass Filipino, Vietnamese and Indonesian vessels operating within their own exclusive economic zones, gradually establishing a normative and operational presence that is increasingly difficult to reverse.

Chinese cyber operations have evolved on a parallel track. Where earlier campaigns emphasised commercial and military espionage, the activity attributed to the threat actor designated Volt Typhoon represents a different and more concerning posture. Beginning in mid-2021 and disclosed publicly by Microsoft in May 2023, Volt Typhoon has compromised United States critical infrastructure across the communications, energy, transportation, water and manufacturing sectors, with a particular focus on facilities in Guam and the continental United States.¹⁵ In a February 2024 Joint Cybersecurity Advisory, the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency, the National Security Agency and the Federal Bureau of Investigation, with international partners, assessed that the operation was not primarily aimed at intelligence collection but at *pre-positioning* — the establishment of persistent access that could be activated to disrupt critical services in the event of a major crisis or conflict, most plausibly involving Taiwan.¹⁶ The director of the Federal Bureau of Investigation, Christopher

¹³Livermore D. China's 'Three Warfares' in theory and practice in the South China Sea. *Georgetown Security Studies Review*. 2018 Mar 25.

¹⁴Permanent Court of Arbitration. *The South China Sea Arbitration (The Republic of the Philippines v. The People's Republic of China)*. Award. PCA Case No. 2013-19; 2016 Jul 12.

¹⁵Microsoft Threat Intelligence. Volt Typhoon targets US critical infrastructure with living-off-the-land techniques. Redmond (WA): Microsoft Security Blog; 2023 May 24.

¹⁶Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency, National Security Agency, Federal Bureau of Investigation, et al. PRC state-sponsored actors compromise and maintain

Wray, described Volt Typhoon to Congress as the defining cyber threat of the present generation.

The Chinese approach is distinguished from the Russian by its patience, its institutional integration, and its willingness to absorb diplomatic costs in pursuit of strategic objectives that may not be realised for decades. Where Russian operations frequently aim to destabilise, Chinese operations more often aim to *normalise* — to render an altered status quo so familiar that reversal becomes politically and operationally infeasible.

4.3 Iran: proxies, asymmetric deterrence and the cyber periphery

4.4 A note on Stuxnet and the asymmetry of attribution

It is important to acknowledge, before proceeding to the question of Western response, that Western states have themselves operated in the grey zone, and have on occasion done so in ways that arguably exceeded the upper threshold. The most prominent example is Operation Olympic Games, the joint United States–Israeli cyber operation that produced the Stuxnet worm and used it to inflict physical damage on Iranian uranium-enrichment centrifuges at the Natanz facility between approximately 2007 and 2010. According to the most authoritative public account, the operation was developed jointly by the United States National Security Agency and the Israel Defense Forces' signals intelligence unit, Unit 8200, with overall operational responsibility resting with the Central Intelligence Agency.¹⁷ The malware was discovered in mid-2010 after a programming error allowed it to propagate beyond the air-gapped Natanz network and into commercial systems.¹⁸

Stuxnet remains, more than fifteen years after its discovery, the most consequential example of a state-sponsored cyber operation producing kinetic effects on critical infrastructure. Its inclusion here serves two purposes. First, it underscores that grey zone competition is not exclusively a problem of authoritarian behaviour: the toolkit is universal, and any analysis that treats Western use of these tools as categorically different risks moral inconsistency. Second, it illustrates the genuine difficulty of establishing thresholds. The Stuxnet operation arguably crossed into what would, in the kinetic domain, constitute a use of

persistent access to U.S. critical infrastructure. Joint Cybersecurity Advisory AA24-038A. Washington (DC): CISA; 2024 Feb 7.

¹⁷Sanger DE. *Confront and Conceal: Obama's Secret Wars and Surprising Use of American Power*. New York: Crown; 2012. p. 188–225.

¹⁸Zetter K. *Countdown to Zero Day: Stuxnet and the Launch of the World's First Digital Weapon*. New York: Crown; 2014.

force; that it has not been treated as such reflects the immaturity of the legal and doctrinal frameworks governing cyber operations rather than any settled view about its character.

5. Why Open Societies Struggle

5.1 The attribution gap

The first structural disadvantage is the attribution gap. Liberal democracies operate under evidentiary standards — public, defensible, judicially reviewable — that authoritarian adversaries do not share. The result is a persistent asymmetry: an authoritarian state can act on intelligence assessments at speed; a democratic state must marshal a public case before it can respond. The intervening delay is itself strategically valuable to the perpetrator.

5.2 Asymmetric escalation tolerance

The second is asymmetric tolerance for escalation. Authoritarian regimes face fewer domestic political costs from confrontation, and in some cases derive positive benefit from external tension. Democracies, by contrast, are constrained by electorates that prefer de-escalation, by alliance structures that require consensus, and by economic interests that lobby against retaliatory measures.

5.3 Doctrinal and legal lag

The third is doctrinal and legal lag. The bodies of international law that govern armed conflict — the Geneva Conventions, the United Nations Charter framework on the use of force, the customary law of state responsibility — were developed for a world in which the relevant categories were comparatively clear. Their application to cyber operations, to maritime militia activity, and to influence operations remains genuinely contested. The Tallinn Manual process and successor initiatives have made progress, but no equivalent of the laws of armed conflict yet exists for the grey zone.

5.4 The coordination problem

The fourth is the coordination problem. Effective response to grey zone activity requires integration across military, intelligence, law enforcement, diplomatic, regulatory, financial and commercial actors. In most Western states, these actors operate under different statutes, different ministries, and different cultures of risk. The result is that responses to grey zone activity are typically slower, less coherent and less proportionate than the operations to which they respond.

6. Policy Recommendations

6.1 Lower the threshold for public attribution

Government should adopt a presumption in favour of attributing hostile grey zone activity at the earliest point at which a credible intelligence assessment can be supported. The cost of occasional misattribution, properly managed, is lower than the cost of permitting adversaries to operate indefinitely under cover of forensic ambiguity.

6.2 Build deterrence through denial, not punishment

Deterrence-by-punishment, as classically understood, has limited application in a domain characterised by deniability and asymmetric escalation tolerance. The more productive investment is in deterrence-by-denial: hardening the targets, raising the operational cost to the attacker, and reducing the strategic return that grey zone operations can plausibly deliver. The protection of critical undersea infrastructure under NATO's Baltic Sentry framework is a useful first model.

6.3 Integrate civil and military instruments

The institutional separation between defence, intelligence, law enforcement and regulatory agencies — appropriate in many respects — is a serious liability in the grey zone. Government should consider whether existing structures (the National Security Council, the National Cyber Security Centre, sector-specific regulators) are adequate to the task, or whether a dedicated cross-government coordinating body is required.

6.4 Invest in alliance-level resilience

No single Western state can defend itself adequately in the grey zone alone. The United Kingdom's most consequential investments are likely to be in alliance-level capabilities: shared attribution infrastructure, integrated maritime surveillance, joint cyber defence, and coordinated diplomatic and economic response. The Five Eyes intelligence partnership and NATO are the obvious vehicles, but new sub-coalitions may be required for specific domains.

6.5 Develop a public doctrine

Finally, government should publish a coherent doctrine for grey zone competition. The absence of such a doctrine — the gap between the activities Western states are willing to conduct, and the activities they are willing to acknowledge — is itself exploited by adversaries. A published doctrine would not eliminate ambiguity, but it would establish thresholds, signal commitments,

and provide the legal and political framework within which response decisions could be made and defended.

7. Conclusion

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